

RUMORS OF BREAD IN THE HOUSE OF BREAD

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Ruth 1:1-6 *“Now it came to pass in the days when the judges ruled, that there was a famine in the land. And a certain man of Bethlehem Judah went to sojourn in the country of Moab, he, and his wife, and his two sons. ²And the name of the man was Elimelech, and the name of his wife Naomi, and the name of his two sons Mahlon and Chilion, Ephrathites of Bethlehem Judah. And they came into the country of Moab, and continued there. ³And Elimelech Naomi's husband died; and she was left, and her two sons. ⁴And they took them wives of the women of Moab; the name of the one was Orpah, and the name of the other Ruth: and they dwelled there about ten years. ⁵And Mahlon and Chilion died also both of them; and the woman was left of her two sons and her husband. ⁶Then she arose with her daughters in law, that she might return from the country of Moab: for she had heard in the country of*

*Moab how that the Lord had visited his people
in giving them bread.”*

INTRO: The Book of Ruth is a relatively small book, covering only four chapters and 85 verses. This book is somewhat unique in that it is difficult to preach from without preaching the entire book. So tonight I would like to preach all four chapters and 85 verses. (Just kidding!)

As I preach tonight I would like for you to **keep** several things **in mind:** **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME & LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

- Bethlehem Judah represents the Church
- Moab represents the world
- Elimelech, Naomi, Mahlon and Chilion represent the backslider
- Ruth and Orpah represent the un-churched
- The “*Bread*” represents the presence of God
- Boaz represents Jesus

I. THE CONSEQUENCES OF A FAMINE IN THE CHURCH

Bethlehem Judah had probably been home to Elimelech, Naomi and their son’s for most, if not all of their lives. The reason I believe

Bethlehem Judah represents the church is that its very name means "*The house of bread*"!

Historically bread has always been the one thing that was an indicator of the presence of God. In Old Testament worship bread occupied a very important place in the form of the showbread. This showbread was called "*The bread of The Presence*". **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

Elimelech, Naomi and their family had no doubt developed lifelong relationships, and probably never had a thought of living anywhere other than Bethlehem. Yet, the Word of God tells us that this family of four pulled up stakes and moved to Moab. This is no small decision; it is a life shift. This decision necessitated:

- Leaving their family
- Leaving their property
- Leaving their neighborhood
- Leaving their school
- Leaving their doctor
- Leaving their synagogue
- Leaving their Wal-Mart

The reason given for this radical life shift was because ***“there was a famine in the land.”*** A famine will cause one to make unthinkable, irrational, unbelievable choices.

The very land that had been known for raising the necessary ingredients for making and manufacturing bread could no longer sustain its residents, because it had become barren.

Moab is a type of the world, in essence Elimelech, Naomi and their two sons backslid and moved to Moab. Friends that is absolutely tragic. What’s more tragic than the move they made is why they made the move, there was ***“no bread in the house of bread.”***

The Pentecostal Church in America has been in the midst of a famine; there is ***“not enough bread in the house of bread.”*** Think of the churches who at one time feasted at the table of God, ate bread at the Lord’s table, and for whatever reason they have decided to move to Moab. (You don’t have to believe to belong – We don’t give altar calls because we don’t want to offend our clients – My experience in looking for a church for Tim & Constance Carnell to attend)

I want to ask Pastors and church leaders, if the world came to your door tonight, what would they discover? Would they find fresh baked bread from the ovens of Heaven, or would they discover offices full of recipes for bread, cold ovens, and dusty barren shelves?

The very best some churches have to offer to those who wander through their doors in search of bread is to give them permission to search through the carpet for a few crumbs of yester-year's revivals. The crumbs will NEVER satisfy the hungry soul!

Just as the light burning continually in the Temple was the responsibility of the Old Testament Priest, pastor, church leader, your ultimate responsibility is to keep the bread baking!

Is it possible that we have become so preoccupied with sweeping out imaginary crumbs from bakeries with no bread that we are not even aware that we are in the midst of a famine?

God wants to restore the sense of His awesome manifest presence in our lives and places of worship. Over and over we talk about the glory

of God covering the earth, but how is His Glory going to flow through the streets of our cities if it can't even flow down the aisles of our churches?

If we are going to have bread in the house of bread we must start somewhere, and it's not going to start out there, it must start in here!

For the presence of God to be rediscovered in the Church four things must happen: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**
(START THROWING BREAD)

- Someone must pay the price to have bread in the house of bread
- We must be willing to lay aside our agenda, and become willing to abide by His agenda, and His alone
- We must be willing to be a consumer and distributor of the bread of His presence
- We must be hungry *“He hath filled the hungry with good things, the rich He hath sent empty away.”*

Ron Phillips stated just recently that there are more people being filled with the Holy Spirit in Baptist churches in America than there are in the Pentecostal Church! Ezekiel wrote: *“...I saw water coming out from under the*

threshold of the door of the Temple..." (Ezek. 47:1) Susan recently released a word over our Church, *"The drought is over"*.

Are we going to allow a famine to continue to rob us of the ability to raise the necessary ingredients to manufacture bread? Are we going to be satisfied to talk about bread, and distribute our products as if they have been rationed?

Or are we going to rise up by faith with bulldog determination and build a bakery that manufactures fresh bread?

II. THE HIGH COST OF BACKSLIDING

The priority of God's presence has been lost in the majority of the modern church. We're like bakeries that are open, but have no bread.

When there is no bread in the house of bread backsliding will accelerate. People will walk away disillusioned, many of them will never return. Are we willing to take that risk?

Elimelech, Naomi and their boy's didn't just wake up one morning and decide to throw all their belongings in the back of a wagon and

move from Bethlehem to Moab! They probably sat around and discussed their options. (Life and death is in the power of the tongue!)

Elimelech, Naomi and their son's lived in a backslidden condition for ten years. A family of four persons left Bethlehem and only one of them ever returned. Elimelech, Mahlon and Chilion never came home they died in Moab!

Pastors and church leaders, if people backslide because of a famine in our church, **Church leaders will be held personally responsible for the lack of bread in the house! (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** (Mercy Gate vision)

III. RUMORS OF BREAD REACH MOAB

Naomi discovered: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Moab is a cruel place
- Moab will steal your children from you and bury them before their time
- Moab will cause you to embrace things you know are wrong
- Moab will rob you of the vitality of life

In the final analysis, all that Naomi had left were two daughters-in-law whom she had known only ten years or less. With nothing but a gloomy and disastrous future staring her in the face, she told them, "***You might as well not hang around me either. I don't have any more sons to give you.***"

Some of the most heartening words in this Book are found in Ruth 1:6 "***...she had heard in the country of Moab how that the Lord had visited his people in giving them bread.***"

There is an information grapevine that winds its way through every community, hamlet, and city of the world. It winds its way down all our coasts, over every mountain range, and into every place where men and women dwell. It is the "*grapevine of the hungry.*"

The news of fresh bread in the house of bread will leapfrog from one household to the other, from one place to another almost instantaneously. The news will break, and people will start coming out of the woodwork. The backsliders will come back to the church en masse! (My prediction of the future of the Pentecostal church – It is going to be difficult

for preachers who have made a production of leaving the house of bread to walk it back)

The first thing one must do to build a Pentecostal church is to make sure there is bread in the house of bread.

When Naomi returned to Bethlehem she brought Ruth with her. Ruth was a Moabitess. When the rumors of bread start circulating, the backsliders will return and they will bring the world with them. **“Whither thou goest, I will go; and where thou lodgest, I will lodge: thy people shall be my people, and thy God my God: ¹⁷Where thou diest, will I die, and there will I be buried: the Lord do so to me, and more also, if ought but death part thee and me.”**

IV. RUMORS OF BREAD BECOME REALITY

Notice the words of Naomi to the residents of Bethlehem when she returned home, Ruth 1:21 **“I went out full, and the Lord hath brought me home again empty: why then call ye me Naomi, seeing the Lord hath testified against me, and the Almighty hath afflicted me?”**

Two significant things are pointed out in this passage of Scripture: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The worst day in the church is better than the best day in the world
- Naomi's name means "pleasant" but 10 years of living in the world had made her life very unpleasant

When Naomi and Ruth arrived in Bethlehem, Ruth went job hunting. Ruth 2:3 ***"So she went out and began to glean in the fields behind the harvesters. As it turned out, she found herself working in a field belonging to Boaz, who was from the clan of Elimelech."***

Boaz: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Notices Ruth... Ruth 2:5 ***"Whose young woman is that?"***
- Makes a place for Ruth... Ruth 2:8 ***"So Boaz said, Don't go and glean in another field and don't go away from here. Stay here with my servant girls."***
- Offers Ruth his protection... Ruth 2:9 ***"I have told the men not to touch you."***

- Romances Ruth... Ruth 2:14 "Come over here. Have some bread and dip it in the wine vinegar."
- Provides for Ruth... Ruth 2:16 "Pull out some stalks for her from the bundles and leave them for her to pick up on purpose." (Have someone to illustrate this by being dressed in a Biblical costume and pick up crumbs)
- The favor of Boaz was evident from a distance... Ruth 2:19 "And her mother-in-law said to her, "Where have you gleaned today? And where did you work? Blessed be the one who took notice of you."
- Falls in love with Ruth... Ruth 3:9-11 "Who are you?" he asked. "I am your servant Ruth," she said. "Spread the corner of your garment over me, since you are a kinsman-redeemer." ¹⁰"The Lord bless you, my daughter," he replied. "This kindness is greater than that which you showed earlier: You have not run after the younger men, whether rich or poor. ¹¹And now, my daughter, don't be afraid. I will do for you all you ask. All my fellow townsmen know that you are a woman of noble character."

Boaz performed the duties necessary to have the right to Naomi's property, and to marry Ruth! Ruth 4:13 ***"So Boaz took Ruth and she became his wife..."***

Because of Ruth's marriage to Boaz she conceived children. Naomi became a grandmother, and Ruth became an ancestor of David and Jesus! Ruth 4:17 ***"Naomi has a son." And they named him Obed. He was the father of Jesse, the father of David."***

When the church reconnects to Jesus; sons and daughters are born into the Kingdom of God! CHURCH LEADERS, BAKE BREAD!

Because of her marriage to Boaz, Ruth and Naomi would never have to worry about having enough bread again! **(THE HOT SIGN AT KRISPI KREME – PUT UP A SIGN OR PICTURES OR VICEO OF THE PROCESS OF KRISPI KREME DONUTS)** CHURCH LEADERS, BAKE BREAD!

As long as we stay married to the Lord of the Church, there will always be ***"bread in the house of bread!"*** CHURCH LEADERS, BAKE BREAD!

I am thoroughly convinced that God is doing everything in his power to place “*bread*” back into the house of bread. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SERVICE)** CHURCH LEADERS, BAKE BREAD!

Will you help bake some heavenly bread to be distributed in a world that is experiencing a very costly and devastating famine? CHURCH LEADERS, BAKE BREAD!